Session 22

2025-09-21

1 - A head in the road

~12:00, 27 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Nyx rides ahead of the carts to settle what the painted thing at the crossroads actually is, and at close range it resolves not as a stone at all but as a man's head — a human buried up to the neck in the middle of the roadway, the word *"Oathbreaker"* scrawled across his forehead in red paint, unconscious but still breathing.
2. The caravan to a man wants to leave him where he lies — the man surely deserved whatever got him there — but the party overrules them, and Nuberroca sets to the digging himself, slow work with his hands and the butt of his lance. Amidamaru waits at the side with water and healing, and when the hole is deep enough and the first touch lands the man comes round with mud still thick in his beard.
3. As the dirt comes off his shoulders a tattoo surfaces on bare skin — a harp within a crescent moon, which Nyx reads at a glance and keeps to herself for now. Clothes come out of one of the packs; the man is dressed and settled in the back of a trailing wagon.
4. He gives his name as **Carlon Amoffel** and tells, first for the merchants' benefit, a broken-engagement story — the oath he broke was a promise to marry a woman whose father and brothers all turned out to be bandits, and who had expected him, once the marriage was sealed, to come into the trade with them. When he refused them — the oath and the trade both — the brothers tracked him down on the road and planted him here in answer. The merchants mostly nod and look relieved.
5. Off to one side of the halt, away from the circle around Amoffel, Sinsong is at **Targutai**'s flank. The griffon is hitched into one of the carts in place of a missing horse, and the arrangement has been getting worse by the day — Targutai would sooner eat the horse next to him than pull alongside it, and the only thing keeping him in the traces is Sinsong's steady handling, a hand on the harness and every trick he has for a difficult beast. When that falls short he lays a word of command on him — *hold* — and the halt passes without blood on the harness, barely.
6. At the next rest stop Nyx draws Amoffel aside with Mialee at her shoulder, and they identify as Harpers themselves — at which the cover falls away. He had been riding infiltrated with a caravan a few days ahead of this one — a merchant convoy with cultists hidden among the merchants — and when the cultists made him, they fed the merchants the story that he was passing intel to bandits; the merchants, unwilling to kill him outright, left him buried in the road to let providence decide his fate.
7. The hunt is the same one — the stolen loot moving north — and the name **Leosin** is already in his mouth before anyone offers it. He names **Vauser** too, a half-orc Harper contact in Waterdeep: muscular, red-haired, a scar running across his face, reachable at *The Broken Jar* when the party gets that far.
8. Amoffel takes a place in one of the back wagons. The party briefs him of their situation, the three carts at the front of the caravan are the cultists, and the loot has been identified. Then they ask for his help against them, he agrees, and from here he rides with the caravan as a third Harper on the trail.
9. The following days go by without any remarkable event as the caravan progresses through the Trade Way.

2 - Dragonspear Castle

16:00, 30 Uktar 1489 DR

1. By the afternoon of the last day of Uktar the road turns west around a long shallow rise, and the ruins come into view — a hulk of blackened stone standing in a sea of grass, towers broken down, walls staved in, a low mist clinging to the ground around the foundations even under the midday sun.
2. **Eldkin** rides up out of the caravan's middle to Nyx's side, as if the sight of the stones has pulled her forward out of the line, and names the place quietly, for Nyx alone to hear — **Dragonspear Castle**. A dwarven fortress once, she says, raised by one of her own.
3. She tells Nyx what she will. It had been built by a dwarf called **Daeros Dragonspear**, long before her grandfathers were born, with an artefact weapon set at its heart that gave the castle its name. For a time it stood as a hold of her people on the High Moor — her kin in the halls and dwarven runes cut deep into the stone above the gate.
4. Then it fell — to fiends, she says. They came up from somewhere under the stones. Her kin bled for the hold of the place twice over, and in the end the castle was ruined and nothing the dwarves had set in it was ever recovered.
5. Today it sits as the party sees it — mist on the ground that does not clear, no smoke from any hearth, no voice of any watch — and the merchants steer the carts a touch wider as they pass. Eldkin does not look back as the road carries on, and Nyx does not press her for more.

3 - The golden stag

1. Later that day the road rises past a stretch of open ground, and late sunlight falls on the hillside where a herd of deer grazes in the grass. Among them stands a stag whose coat catches the light like beaten gold, antlers like platinum. The caravan halts at the sight.
2. Half the guards reach straight for their bows — that hide would pay a season, meat for a week, a trophy worth a year of road — the other half hold back, hands raised: a creature coloured like that is not game, it is omen, and bringing it down will bring worse down behind it.
3. As the archers start running toward the hill, Nyx throws a cloud of fog across the slope, dense and low; the hunters lose line of sight and the stag within it, and in the thick of the mist they scatter in different directions after a glimpse that is no longer there.
4. Behind the mist the party divides. Nyx has caught the stag's trail at the far side of the fog and goes after it; Mialee and Nuberroca go with her. Sinsong, Eguzkilore, and Amidamaru stay with the carts to settle the hunters when they come back empty-handed.
5. The chase runs harder than any deer should, and the three of them follow at a long pace through the brush. Somewhere in the ground where the trail turns in on itself Nuberroca loses the track and falls behind; Nyx and Mialee come on alone at last to a moss-grown, ivy-draped ruin in a wooded hollow — a ring of fallen stones, roofless, the trees crowded close against the walls.
6. The stag is already standing there when they arrive, light still on his coat though the sun has fallen below the trees. He turns at the stones and speaks — Sylvan, carrying across the clearing. Nyx takes it in as a Fey-speaker. Mialee hears it through a spell for the understanding of tongues.
7. Behind the shape of the stag both of them feel the hand of **Silvanus** — god of wild places, of what grows and keeps watch. Neither of them speaks the name aloud. Both of them lower their bows.
8. ***[EPIC]*** The stag confirms they are on the right track, and leaves the prophecy on them: ***"Follow the river of gold until you reach the castle in the sky. Your path will be filled with hardship and blood. Not all will survive..."***
9. When the voice goes silent a longbow is lying at their feet — a deer head carved into the grip, its antlers forming the bow itself. The stag fades into the trees between one breath and the next. Nyx takes up the bow.
10. In the silence of the clearing the two of them stand a long moment with the prophecy still in the air between them. Then the last of the daylight goes out of the trees and they turn back the way they came, to find Nuberroca on the back-trail and the caravan still halted on the road.

4 - Diverse rites

~11:00, Feast of the Moon 1489 DR

1. The Feast of the Moon falls between the last day of Uktar and the first of Nightal — a day set apart from the months, and from the road. By mid-morning the carts have drawn up to a roadside tavern still within sight of Dragonspear Castle to the east, and halt there for the full day.
2. The tavern halt is the worst yet for Targutai. The stable fills with the caravan's horses one after another, and the griffon — lashed off to a corner of the yard well out of range of them — strains and screams every time one is led past. Sinsong is at his side through the long morning, hand on his neck and voice low; when the handling will not hold he lays a slumber spell on him and the beast goes down for a span, and wakes angrier each time.
3. The hours otherwise pass easily enough: horses rested, harness mended, bread and salt-pork taken under the awning. By late afternoon the sun hangs low to the west and the first bite of winter has come in on the air; as dusk drops the lamps come alight in the common room, and the caravan folk begin to set themselves for the three rites of the day.
4. Eldkin keeps her own rite out in the tavern yard, apart from the warm room, at a small fire of her own under the open sky — a dwarven Commemoration of the Fallen. She has set a flat stone before her, and as each name goes into the fire she tips a measure of ale onto it for the dead to drink.
5. Nyx comes out and sits with her, and the names Eldkin speaks under her breath are no longer only her private grief. Daeros Dragonspear she names first, raiser of the castle on the High Moor. Then the names of her kin who held the hold in the two sieges and did not come out of it — a dozen names and more, one after another, until the ale is gone and the small fire between them has run down to coals.
6. Inside the tavern the main fire belongs to Shiallia: a feast built at the hearth, warm cider in hands, bread broken and passed from table to table, caravan voices and the tavern's own folk rising together in old road-songs across the room.
7. In one corner a short Lliira observance has gone up as well — a weapon laid flat on the ground under a scatter of flowers, chanted over quietly.
8. The rest of the party take their places at the long table and the hearth, warming hands and passing the cider, but stay outside the Ritual of Remembrance; the stories told that night belong to other travellers.
9. Long after the second cask has been broached the common room thins and the fire settles, and the party find their pallets along the wall. Out in the yard Eldkin stays with her coals until they are properly dark; Nyx stays with her, and does not leave her alone.

5 – Heroes of Mansken

~13:00, 1 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The first day of Nightal opens cold and grey, and the caravan is slow to leave — the Feast night has run its wake, and the merchants have agreed to take a midday meal at the tavern before the road. The common room fills with caravaners and tavern-locals over bowls of stew and warm bread, and Amidamaru stands up at the long table and asks for a word.
2. He tells the locals the long road behind the caravan: the fungus-field with its black spores that pinned the carts until the way was cut open; the lone troll Nuberroca talked down in the marshes of the Trollclaws with a handful of rations; the night the other trolls came at the camp out of the dark and the pyres on both sides the next morning — and here his voice turns cold with hate at the **Company of the Boar**, paid in coin to guard that very camp and gone from it before the first blade fell, taking four horses and the caravan's trust with them. He closes on yesterday — the golden stag at the ruined stones and the Sylvan voice on the wind — and names each of the party in their turn by what they did.
3. When the story runs to its edge, Amidamaru names the party itself for the first time — ***"The Heroes of Mansken"*** — and the name lands outside their own mouths at last. The caravan folk pound the table with their cups; the tavern-locals follow because the caravan has; someone starts a song before the bowls are cleared.
4. Before the carts roll out into the afternoon, Amidamaru pulls a square of paper from his pack and spreads it on the table in front of him. The locals lean in. In a careful hand he writes down the shape of what he has just told — the long road, the trolls fought, the forest-god met at the end — and one by one each of the party puts their mark under the banner of *"The Heroes of Mansken"*. He pins the paper to the beam above the hearth, so that the next traveller to stop here will have a name to put to the tale.

6 – Sinsong flies north

~16:00, 1 Nightal 1489 DR

1. By mid-afternoon the carts have rolled out from the tavern and the caravan has settled back into the road, the mood still high after the festival.
2. It does not last. Three hours out of the tavern Targutai breaks the line on the carthorse beside him again — this time to the throat, a tear that would have killed the beast outright but for Amidamaru's hand the moment after. The merchants will not have it any longer; cries go up along the carts to cut the griffon loose and leave him in the ditch for the crows.
3. Sinsong stops it before it goes further. He steps between the merchants and the harness and says what he has been thinking all day: Targutai cannot be held in traces another hour, and he will not leave him to be killed on the road. He will take the griffon up and go north instead — the Company of the Boar is days ahead of them on the Trade Way, but a griffon can cut that distance fast.
4. He frees Targutai from the harness and talks him down one last time; the griffon settles the moment he is out of the line of horses, farther from his preferred prey. Sinsong packs for several days on the wing — rations enough to last him until he can hunt his own, a bedroll, water-skins and his stones, every last thing he carries on the road — and straps the saddle to the griffon's back. Nyx offers to come. He refuses her — this is his to do, and the caravan still has need of a scout.
5. He swings up into the saddle and Targutai goes. One long run of the claws on the wet verge, one great beat of the wings, and the griffon is rising over the treeline with Sinsong black against the grey sky. The party watch him climb north along the line of the Trade Way until he is a shape no bigger than a bird. The road carries on, and the rest of them with it, under the promise to meet again soon.

7 - No room at the inn

~13:00, 11 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The first tenday of Nightal ran cold and wet through deepening winter — rain on and off since the second day, no stretch of dry road for more than a morning at a time, the merchants' cloaks never quite drying between halts. Nothing on the road worth the telling.
2. By midday of the eleventh the caravan draws up to a large roadside inn standing alone on the grey land, smoke from its chimney the only thing moving in the rain. Two women are already outside under the awning, drenched and out of options — twin sisters **Arietta** and **Zelina Innevar**, bound for Waterdeep themselves and turned away from the door.
3. Eguzkilore draws alongside them with a general greeting, and the sisters pick him up with a cordial flirtation; Nyx joins the circle and Amidamaru stands with them under the awning. Names are exchanged, and the shared destination of Waterdeep.
4. Nuberroca stops at the awning long enough for the sisters to catch his eye before Mialee pulls him through the door. The common room is empty but for four men at the one lit table — three swordsmen with blades at their hips and the build of men who use them, and at their head a noble in rich clothes and an elegant red cap, plainly the one carrying the voice. On the table between them sits a strange **lamp** that emits a soft blue light.
5. **Barlon** the innkeeper bows to the newcomers, polite and apologetic: the noble has paid for the *whole* inn — the common room and every room upstairs. When Nuberroca asks about the stables, one of the guards at the table calls over, loud enough to be heard across the room: his master's horses are high-bred, and will not rest anywhere near the filthy animals from the caravan. They have had to rent out the whole stable too, he says, to keep the two apart.
6. The four at the table laugh at the goliath and drop the next jibe at his expense, then settle back to their hands of cards around the blue lamp.
7. Nuberroca stands his ground with Mialee at his side; Barlon moves between them pleading, while the four at the table watch pointedly bored and ready.